

The Iran African project

THEME: Cultural commonalities; Capacities and opportunities

There's a common link between Iran and Africa on the aspects of tradition and modernity. In the nineteenth century period, leading European countries with Britain at the helms made colonial expansion their major objective. For example, the Anglo-Russian Entente (1907) gave Britain a part of Persia, Iran a spheres of influence. In fact, Britain used Persian, now Iranian territory as a base for military operations against the Othomans during World War 1. Britain assisted Reza Pihlari to become shah and Britain moved into all of Persia with the successful, socialist Bolshevik Revolution of 1917 in Russia. The shah propelled Iran into the path of modernization and secularization. The in 1935, persia's name was changed to Iran.

The Berlin conference of 1884/1885 led to the scramble for Africa by powerful European countries, notably France, Germany, Belgium, Portugal and Britain. These countries carved out territories for themselves in the African continent. These colonial masters spearheaded cultural commonalities, capacities, science and technology. This westernization of Africa by the European countries was what obtained Iran prior to the Iranian Revolution of 1979. Using Nigeria as a case study, Sir Fredrick Luggard was brought from India to oversee the conquered territories of Britain at the gulf of Guinea. Lord Luggard amalgamated the Northern and Southern Protectorates to become one country which Lady Flora Shaw called Nigeria (R. Niger area). So, since Iran and Africa passed through a phase of colonialism by European countries, it was the same for African countries, which cement their bond of commonalities. This indicates that there is a congruence of cultural opportunities and capacities for Iran and Africa even now and in the future.

RELIGION IN THE CULTURAL AND SOCIAL SYSTEM OF IRAN AND AFRICA

Africa had in times past engaged in various forms of traditional religion. Around 1000-1100 A.D, Islamic teachers had begun crossing the Sahara desert from N.Africaa. These Islamic scholars spearhead the belief in monotheism as against Africans' polytheism. Arabic language came with Islamic Education and the belief one God, Allah. With Africa's multi-cultural and ethnic with linguistic diversity, islam spread and united ancient Empires of Songhai, Mali, Kanem Bornu to mention but a few. The oldest university is said to be at Timbukutu. We learnt Uthman Dan Fodio, an Islamic scholar who led a religious war, called jihad across West Africa. He established the Sokoto Empire which spanned from Niger Republic, Benin republic and a greater part of Nigeria to as far as Edo State after Kogi State. The Hausa-Fulani acronym was formulated for about a century before British soldiers annexed the Sokoto Empire and its theocracy in 1910. The mixture of these ethnic and linguistic groups in the South part of the Gulf of Guinea were the amalgamated in 1914 by Sir Fredrick Luggard. Similar colonial exploits overran the Northern, Central< Eastern and Southern territories of Africa.

The Iranians are a considerable ethnic and Linguistic diversity like Africans. The Aryans, Turks,Arabs and Mongols have contributed to the ethnic mixture in Iran. Arabic language is spoken by some Iranians, though the official language is Farsi, which about 80% of the Iranians speak. It should be noted however that the establishment of Afro-Iranian communities, which was to a great extend due to the slave trading activities of Arabs, Persians and Indians at the Persian Gulf in the 19th century. The African displacement has reconstructed a new identity influenced by both Africa and Iran itself. For example, the Zar religious ritual obtains in Iran as well and Africa.

This historical connection between Iran and Africa was established through trading activities as early as the 19th century. Significant consequences of such commercial and geographical linkage led to the cultural exchange and population movement in both directions. For example, Iranian merchants have had Mangrove trade with Kenya, Somelia and Tangayika as early as 933AD. Which they exchanged with ceramics made in

Firozah (Southern Iran) Lari, a currency minted in Lar, Fars Province was a medium of exchange in muscat and some African Cities. Tortoise shells, teakwood, Ivory, ambergris and slaves were exported from East Africa to Iran.

Without mincing words, there's a cultural heritage between Africans and Iranians since times. This is evidenced in the mutual influence of Africa and the host society (Iran) to mention but a few, music, dance, and spirit possession were significant cultural characteristics of the African diaspora in Iran. This is influenced by the Islamic and cultural elements of the society on one hand and which was transformed by indigenous practices on the other. This mutual impact contributed or facilitated the continuity of the African heritage, by making a significant impact on the Iranian society. In a nutshell, an Iranian-African "project" has had its foundations laid by mercantile trade as early as the 10th century AID.

CONTRIBUTION OF EDUCATION TO BILATERAL CULTURAL COOPERATION

The most outstanding cultural commonalities capacities and opportunities are seen in Iranian education. Iranians have had access to free education from primary school to university. This is a feat, African countries are yet to boast. Iranian government has equalized education attainment between genders. However, private education at both university and high school levels now makes education depend greatly on family resources. This is also most common in African countries. Iran however, leads African nations on the parity of education of its citizens which is a cue to be highlighted and followed in this "Iran-African project"

TOLERANCE AND NON-VIOLENCE IN THE CULTURAL STRUCTURE AND RELIGIOUS INSTITUTIONS OF AFRICA AND IRAN

From an objective and sociological perspective, there has been growing animosity to Iran within the muslim world. This was aggravated by the misbehavior of some Iranian Pilgrims making the haj in Mecca, Saudi Arabia, more than once, led to violence and deaths. From Dec 5-9, 2016 the pare Christi International an international catholic peace movement at its Nonviolence in Africa, creating a future of tht hope maintained that urges all to apply the golden rule which urges people universally to treat others as they would wish to be treated. The same asserted that the basic teachings of al religions includes nonviolence, tolerance and peace.

The above is in line with the African union agenda 2063 to silence the guns in Africa by 2020. This advocate for nonviolence and peace education in the African society Yong people to be economically empowered to reduce or stop youths restlessness. In line with the Africa-Iranian cooperation, Irans Minister of Foreign Affairs Mohammed Javad made a public speech on the occasion of the 51st anniversary of the African Union in Tehram, The minister praised prominent African leaders and commended them for the establishment of justice and freedom in Africa. He condemned extremism and terrorism perpetuated by the takfiri militant group in iran and the bokoharam especially Nigerian and other African countries since 2009.

On a separate meeting with Iranian ambassadors to African countries, foreign minister Mohammed Javad Zariff said that there are abundant capacities for economic cooperation with the nations of Africa. He briefed them on Iranian foreign policy to enhance level of ties with African countries

DEMOCRACY AND CULTURAL PLURALISM

Iran has a considerable ethnic and linguistic diversity. The Aryans, Arabs, Turks, Mongols etc contribute to Irans ethnic mix. The official language of Iran is Farsis which some 50% of population speak. The Azari Turkish Language is spoken by another 2490 of the population. Local dialect are widespread. This discriptionparallehs African nations' populations especially Nigeria. This diversity of the Arabs world with Iran shows as a case study,shows

Distribution company (NIOPDC) says Iran mills construction of oil refineries in Africa, Sierra Leone is being considered presently with a memoranda of understanding with six African countries to construct small scale refineries. On the occasion of the National Day Celebration in Kenya, Iran's acting Deputy foreign ministers Mortela Sermadi in 2013 on the invitation of Kenya's foreign Minister, Amina Mohammed to exchange views on possible avenues for the expansion of bilateral ties in various economic and political ties. On January 13th 2014, Kenyan senate speaker Ellde Ethuro visited Iran. Mohammed Javad Zarif emphasized on Iran's expansion of relations with Kenya.

On November 10th 2013, Iran reported that the minister of industry, mines and Trade Mohammed Reza Nemat Zadeh said to Africa's ambassadors in Tehran that Iran and African countries should make use of their natural technical engineering potential and capabilities to further boost bilateral economic and trade relations.

He said that Iran favours consultation and cooperation with Kenya in regional and international fields for both countries benefits especially on global terrorism which the UN ratified WAVE. War against violence and extremism needs collective cooperation. Senator Ethuro said that Kenya favours expansion in economic, commercial, agricultural and tourism relations as well as benefit from Iran's experience in every possible field. During the five day visit Ethuro also met with Iranian parliament speaker.

The Somali delegation was in Tehran at the invitation of the first vice speaker of Majilis (Iran's parliament)

ABSTRACT on Religion on the cultural social system of Iran and Africa

The establishment of Afro-Iranian communities was to a great extent due to the slave trading activities of Arabs, Persians and Indians in the Persian Gulf. The 19th century. The African displacement has reconstructed a new identity influenced by both Africa and Iran itself. For example, the Zoroastrian religious ritual obtains in Iran as well as Africa. The historical connection between Iran and Africa was established through trading activities as early as the 19th century. Significant consequences of such commercial and geographical linkages led to cultural exchanges and population movements in both directions. Iranian merchants have had mangrove trade with Kenya, Somalia and Tanganyika as early as 933AD which they exchanged in Muscat and some African countries. Tortoise shell, teakwood Ivory, ambergris and slaves were exported from East Africa to Iran.

In conclusion, there's a cultural heritage between Iranians and Africans. This lies in the mutual influence of Africa and the host society (Iran) music, dance, spirit possession were significant cultural characteristics of the African diaspora in Iran. This is influenced by the Islamic and cultural elements of the society on one hand and was transformed by indigenous practices on the other. This mutual impact facilitated the continuity of the African heritage by making a significant part of Iranian society.

In a nutshell, an Iranian- African "project" has had its foundations laid by merchantile trade as early as the 10th century AD.

The most outstanding cultural commonalities capacities and opportunities are outstanding in education. Iranians have had increased access to free education from primary to university. This has equalized educational attainment between genders. However, private education at both university and high school levels now makes education depend greatly on family resources. African countries need to learn from the experience of Iranian education.

Health and basic services has improved the status of women. The average number of births per woman since 1984-2004 is about two. Access to electricity has improved to 94% piped water 79%. This 80% of house hold owned a reffridgerator,70% a television and 76% a gas stove(Djavad Salehi-isfahani's) poverty, inequality and populist politica in iran in 2008

Easten Europe Rouhani plans to visit south Africa with near future.

From S.Africa,zarif travelled to Uganda and Niger. Several Iranian banks have opened branches in S.Africa by building close ties with African countries, Tegrans hopes to gain their support at the UN, other international and regional platforms and irans naval expansion in the future.